

FROM THE FRINGES
Snippets from the exhibition, which took Thadani seven years to put together







PHOTOGRAPHY

Documenting Life on the Margins

***Broken**, Asha Thadani's exhibition of photographs of Dalit lives, makes us face some uncomfortable realities, but without robbing her subjects of their dignity*

According to self-taught photographer Asha Thadani, her work "has always centred around patterns and boundaries and power structures that define or differentiate the world and the complex ways in which these lines become etched, blurred, brittle and porous". Thadani finds Dalit lives to be on this vulnerable frontier and feels "their inner world is not represented enough". *Broken: Dalit Lives*, her ongoing exhibition at the India Habitat Centre, New Delhi (on till January 7, 2024), addresses this imbalance by showcasing 10 Dalit communities from across India. This is a substantial body of work, still in progress, and the set being exhibited took Thadani seven years to document.

The communities are startlingly diverse. They include the Mallahs, boatmen among whom a sub-group, the *gotakhors*, dive for corpses in the Ganga in exchange for cheap alcohol; the Ramnamis, who have Ram's name tattooed all over their bodies, faces included; the Holeyas, who process goat heads in toxic furnaces and pay the price with shortened life spans; and the Theyyam dancers of the Pulayar community, who subvert caste hierarchy for the duration of their performance. Particularly poignant is the case of the Musashars, rat catchers and eaters, whose stab at acceptability sees them transform into Nachniyas, gender-fluid male dancers who perform at village weddings.

BROKEN showcases 10 Dalit communities across India through a stirring, if unsettling, collection of images

It's a stirring, if unsettling, collection of images with occasional glimmers of hope. In many, the subjects display a clear awareness of being photographed. This is not by accident. "Caste-based discrimination is learned and 'performed' as per the irrational chains of the caste system. In fact, the prejudice is so entrenched and its acceptance by Dalits so implicit that at times, its 'enactment' escapes conscious detection. I wanted to amplify this aspect of Dalit life and portray it as statuesque resilience," says Thadani.

The communities Thadani has documented live on the margins, so they're not easily accessible. Electricity, water and toilets are in short supply. "Our idea of bare minimum is a luxury they do not know and, therefore, cannot imagine," says Thadani. "Being a woman helped, as people are generally more trusting of them." That trust had to be built. "[The communities] are not as apprehensive or sceptical as they are fearful. Having routinely been subject to abuse and marginalisation, they could not wrap their heads around why somebody would want to document and share their life," says Thadani.

Among inspirations, Thadani counts Sebastiao Salgado, especially his 'Workers' series, 19th-century post-mortem photography in the West, and ancient and evolving forms of puppet theatre. She is currently working on a series on gambling in India and another on the juvenile justice system. If her work on Dalits is any indication, Thadani will bring fresh eyes and a sensitive perspective to the subjects she's training her lens on. ■

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